



iPod touch 4G

Price: ₹19,000 (32GB)

PMP

The PMP is a dying breed, fast approaching extinction and very few people actually care about them. This was quite evident this year with very few new and notable PMPs being launched. The culprit here is the smartphone. The mobile is our ever-present companion and with almost all phones coming with 3.5mm jacks and the ability to play back MP3 files, it seems to be sufficient for most of us. Audiophiles will be sorely disappointed by this trend, but they're few and far in between. To curb their appetite, companies like Cowon and Sony keep churning out audiophile grade PMPs at intervals. The PMP has become so much more that in a way, you can say that the PMP has evolved into a smartphone or vice-versa.

Zero1 Winner

Apple iPod touch 4G

The iPod touch 4G is this year's Zero1 Award winner. A PMP that needs no introduction, the iPod touch was the winner last year as well. Currently called the iPod touch 4G, the device comes packed to the gills with every feature that you could ever want on a portable device. Everything except a phone that is. Backed by a solid OS and the world's largest app store, this device is more of a portable computer than a PMP. The audio quality of the device is good as is the quality of volume levels. Of course, PMPs from Sony and Cowon are quite capable of providing competitive sound quality owing to the hardware they use, but very few devices can actually provide the kind of experience this device can.

Worthy Mentions

Sony NWZ E454

The Sony NWZ E454 is a feature-packed PMP in its own way. The features in question are dedicated to music playback, including lyrics support, variable speed playback, sectional looping, karaoke and even SenseMe technology (analyses your tracks and helps categorise them as per different moods). The device is well-built but the slippery finish meant that it almost slipped through our fingers a few times. The bundled earphones are decent in terms of sound quality but lack in comfort and noise isolation. Where the device does shine is in its audio quality. The playback on our reference HD428s was good and we had nothing to complain about. Another thing to note is the UI. It is extremely friendly and intuitive and more geared towards easy database management, reaffirming the belief that it's not just Apple that can come up with a good, intuitive UI.



Sony NWZ E454

Price: ₹6,990 (8GB)



Cowon C2

Price: ₹6,200 (4GB)

Cowon C2

The Cowon C2 tries to pack in much in a tiny form factor which is good, but some things like documents, notepad, etc., seem unnecessary. The resistive touchscreen is also quite sluggish. More focussed on audio, the C2 manages to provide excellent sound quality though the volumes levels are lacking when compared to the Apple iPod Nano. The bundled earphones are decent and provide good isolation, but we feel that a good set of IEMs will bring out the best in this device. It supports almost all audio formats, including lossless formats such as FLAC and WAV. This, coupled with the superb audio quality and the provision of an expansion slot, make it a worthy contender in this category.